

HIDDEN DEPTHS



100 DAILY MEDITATIONS FOR
ROYAL ARCH FREEMASONS

JONTI MARKS

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Hidden Depths.

100 Daily Meditations for Royal Arch Freemasons

Jonti Marks.

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To Jo
for her love and creative support;

To my children,
Malaika, Jesse and Sami;

To my sponsors and patrons for their support, both practical and moral;

And, as ever, to the Brethren and Companions of the Old Bromsgrovian
Lodge and Chapter, 5743, who hold and support me as true Brothers.

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Introduction:

To be honest, it's taken me a very long time to feel that I even begin to understand what Royal Arch Masonry is all about. I know I'm not alone, however, because one of the most common reactions I see from Companions when we talk about our Chapter meetings is a sense of bewilderment and lack of comprehension.

I'm not necessarily saying that I understand it fully even now but, having been through the Principals' chairs, I at least feel that I am familiar enough with the outer form of the ritual to begin to consider its inner meaning.

The main conclusion that I've come to is that the secrets of the Holy Royal Arch are almost inexpressibly profound and personal and if we are to find meaning within its rituals, we have to go very deep indeed, as deep, metaphorically speaking, as the vault into which our ancient Companion was lowered.

This seeking out of the depths, this willingness to search in the darkest places to find the truth, strikes me as one of the keys to an understanding of the Royal Arch. We are called upon to delve into the deepest recesses of what it means to be human – with all the darkness and ignorance that that implies – and then to lay ourselves open to the searing light of truth that we will undoubtedly find if our hearts and minds are open to it.

I found myself writing about God much more in this book than I did in 'Level Steps' and I came to realise that this was another clue to the essence of Royal Arch Masonry. The whole Order, it appears to me, is built around the idea that, as Master Masons who have realised the truth of our own mortality, now is the time to explore, again in depth and with rigorous honesty, the nature of our relationship with God. This has to be done both generally in that we must consider wider humanity's relationship with its Creator, but also very personally in that each one of us must be willing to look deep within ourselves to find and acknowledge that true relationship.

The gradual revealing of some of the names attributed to God also seemed to me to be a key theme. It struck me that the names by which we know God become ever less formal and more intimate as we progress through Lodge and Chapter and I felt that the growing closeness implied in this naming reflected the central idea that, if we are willing to do the work

involved, we will come closer to a true understanding of God and of the relationship that exists eternally between us.

As ever, the thoughts expressed in this little book are my own and do not represent any 'official' view of Freemasonry or of the Royal Arch in particular. It is my great hope that it might help to shine some light on what is undoubtedly a difficult subject and to allow the Royal Arch to grow in the affections of the Companions who work its rituals in the same way that the work of the Lodge is so loved and valued by Brethren all over the world.

It is pure coincidence that this book has been written in the year in which Supreme Grand Chapter celebrates its bicentenary but, for what it's worth, I offer it up as a humble contribution to the efforts being made to stimulate interest in the workings of the Holy Royal Arch and as a signpost to the ineffable beauty that lies hidden deep beneath the surface of its ritual.

JAM
November, 2013

‘May God grant further aid and light to keep us from standing in our own way.’

Goethe

We can never say that our knowledge of the Craft is complete because there is always so much more to learn and understand. But it is the case that the Master Mason’s degree completes the story around which the Craft is structured – the building of the Temple at Jerusalem. How sad, then, that the story ends so inconclusively, so badly. Our secrets are lost, our Master is slain and we are left to contemplate the fragility of our lives and the certainty of our own mortality. But there is more to come. The Craft teaches us much about ourselves, our world and our relationships with each other. The Royal Arch seeks to deepen this understanding and to encourage us to consider all of these things in the light of eternity; to see ourselves in relation to our primary relationship with our Creator. To be successful, we need ‘further aid and light’; we need to be open and to trust ourselves – with God’s help – to follow the right path.

*'He that has light within his own clear breast
May sit i' the center, and enjoy clear day:
But he that hides a dark soul and foul thoughts
Benighted walks under the midday sun;
Himself is his own dungeon.'*

John Milton.

Within the Royal Arch degree there is so much symbolism associated with reaching down into the darkness to find light. It is worth remembering that sometimes the darkest places in our lives are those we create for ourselves, through negative thinking and by allowing ourselves to dwell on the struggles and sufferings that life throws in our way. Life can be hard, there is no doubt about that, but it is very clear that our attitude to the difficulties that beset us determines whether we walk in darkness or light. As Freemasons, we profess adherence to the three principle virtues of Faith, Hope and Love. These three are proof enough against the darkness. With them we can dare to delve into the depths of our souls to free ourselves from the dungeons of our own making.

'Oh thou, who hast called us out of darkness to be bearers of light; we beseech Thee to make us helpers in the world. Take away from us the love of ease, and fear of men. Show us the simple things that we can do to help our neighbours to be good.'

Anon.

Having taken the first steps towards banishing the darkness in our own lives, as Freemasons we are called upon to do more. A deepening knowledge of what it is to be human – a growing understanding of ourselves as pilgrims on a path that leads, ultimately, to unity and peace in their most profound sense – carries with it a great responsibility. Those who carry the torches must hold them high to light the way for others. And so we must commit to live by the virtues we profess to admire. That doesn't mean we must become proselytisers for Freemasonry, trying to convert everyone to our way of thinking. On the contrary, it calls upon each one of us to live quietly and virtuously, a friend to all and an example of how simple goodness can spread from heart to heart.

‘Then wrought Bezaleel and Aholiab, and every wise hearted man, in whom the Lord put wisdom and understanding to know how to work all manner of work for the service of the sanctuary, according to all that the Lord had commanded.’

Exodus 36:1

All of us have to work in one way or another. Even the richest or most relaxed among us have to make some effort everyday to clothe and feed ourselves; to put a roof over our heads; to care for our family, friends and wider connections. As Masons we understand the need to work in different spheres of life – spiritual as well as material – to be fully rounded ourselves. But the wise-hearted know that work done in a spirit of service is always more satisfying than work done for selfish reasons. Freemasons are givers, that much is certainly true, but it is worth remembering that giving is not just about money and charity. If all of our work in this world were done with the service of others – and, through others, God – in mind, how sweet our work would be.

'Reveal to us the wavering ranks of those that are struggling upward that we may cheer and support our comrades unknown.'

Anon.

We can never really know the innermost secrets of another person's heart; their hopes and fears, their joys and desires, their successes and failures, their dreams and aspirations. All we can know is ourselves and that is all we can hope to work on, certainly in terms of our own moral and spiritual evolution. But we can sometimes recognise a fellow pilgrim and we can cheer and support them on their journey. And more than that: by living lives that demonstrate our commitment to those higher values we profess to admire, we can offer support and encouragement to unknown comrades who may pass us by unseen and unheard but who may glance up and recognise in us something that gives them the strength and determination to continue along their path. This is something that we must take on trust but we must never underestimate its power.

‘I pray you with all earnestness to prove and to know within your hearts that things lovely and righteous are possible for those who believe in their possibility, and who determine that for their part they will make each day’s work contribute to them.’

John Ruskin

Just as we often carry with us our own darkness and imprison ourselves in our own dungeons, so do we also have the power within ourselves to create delight and freedom. How profound that loveliness and righteousness are linked here. We all know that material success alone does not bring happiness, does not constitute ‘rightness.’ But what does bring happiness? What does feel right for us, in the depths of our souls? We know the answer to those questions, too. Let us make the commitment to work every day for the common good; to act in ways that contribute to the welfare of all. Let us believe wholeheartedly that lovely and righteous things are possible for us if we behave in ways that will allow them to grow.

*'And silent, before us,
Veiled the dark portal,
Goal of all mortal:
Silent stars rest over us,
Graves under us – silent.'*

Goethe

As Master Masons, we do not shy away from the contemplation of the grave and we understand that, all too soon, that is where we shall lie. But we are also confident in the belief that, beyond the darkness of death, there is light; that death is but a portal, a doorway and that the 'vital and immortal principle' within us will rise again.

As Companions of the Royal Arch, we also know what it is to descend into an unknown darkness and we now discover where light can be found in that darkness: in the word of God.

Let us take a moment – in silence – to contemplate once more our own mortality and to reaffirm our faith that beyond the outer forms of this life, there waits another, greater existence.

‘Pure wisdom always directs itself toward God; the purest wisdom is knowledge of God.’

Lew Wallace

As Entered Apprentices, we are encouraged to study the hidden mysteries of nature and science. As Fellowcrafts, we are enjoined to look more specifically at the liberal arts and sciences. And as Master Masons, we are told that our study should be ourselves; in particular, ourselves as mortals in the light of eternity. In a way, all of this is preparation for the greatest subject of all: the study of our relationship with God. Freemasonry allows us the freedom to conceive of God in whatever way is most meaningful for us but it asks – certainly in the Royal Arch – that we consider most deeply what the implications of our professed faith mean to us. It asks that we apply that understanding in practical ways, in our daily lives and, as always, it offers us guidance on our path, always suggesting the ways that might, eventually, lead us to find the peace we crave.

‘Almighty God, unto whom all hearts be open, all desires known, and from whom no secrets are hid...’

Opening prayer

Whatever we conceive God to be, we generally acknowledge that the Being to whom we assign that name is omniscient: all-knowing. This means that we are known, in our totality, by God. The innermost secrets of our hearts are open; our hopes and desires are known and even our darkest secrets are not hidden. This is, on the one hand, a terrifying thought. We all have hidden depths that we find hard to bring into the light, even in our own minds. But it is also a very liberating thought. If these things are known and open to the One who is the highest power and state of being, why should we fear to acknowledge them ourselves? The very essence of Royal Arch Masonry is the idea that we must plumb the depths and bring light to the darkest recesses of our lives. How joyful to know that God is with us; that we will have support and guidance and love on every step of that difficult journey.

‘Then he answered and spake unto me, saying, This is the word of the Lord unto Zerubbabel, saying, Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the Lord of hosts.’

Zechariah 4:6

Perhaps the greatest lesson that the Royal Arch has to teach us is that to accept the word of God in our lives is the beginning of wisdom and inner peace. Coming, as we do, from so many walks of life, so many countries and cultures and religions, our interpretation and understanding of what is meant by the word of God may differ, but we can agree that it represents that innermost impulse that tells us what is right and what is wrong: what benefits and what harms ourselves and those around us. And, acting from that place of light, we acknowledge the power of truth to actuate us and to keep us on the path that leads, eventually, to our deepest selves and to God.

'We three do meet and agree in Peace, Love, and Unity...'

Opening

In the Royal Arch, nothing is accomplished alone. In Craft Freemasonry, we are, in some respects, alone at every step of the journey. We enter the Lodge in darkness and, in the third degree, it is only after our raising that we are reunited with our 'former companions.' But in the Royal Arch we are never without the help and support of our Companions. The Chapter is ruled by three; three journey to Jerusalem; three assist in the discovery and exploration of the vault. And three, together, bring their discovery before the Court of the Sanhedrin.

The journey from darkness to light is a difficult one. Sometimes we create our own difficulties; sometimes life throws difficulties before us. How good it is to know that we do not have to travel this road alone. How good it is to know that there are those who tread the path with us and that there are those who have gone before us and who are able to guide and counsel us.

How foolish it would be to refuse that help.

‘Do you present yourself with a view to improving in Freemasonry and directing that improvement to the Glory of God, and the good of man?’

Ceremony of Exaltation

Before the ceremony is properly begun in the Chapter, we are reminded about the importance of the work we do. That we have attained a certain level of understanding of Freemasonry is taken as read – we are Master Masons after all – but it is also acknowledged that we can learn more, that we can improve. This doesn’t mean, necessarily, that we must become better ritualists but, more importantly, that we can always deepen our understanding of the lessons that lie within our rituals. We can always become better people by putting those lessons into practice in our lives and, right from our entry into the Chapter, it is stated, without equivocation, that by choosing to make ourselves better people, we can glorify God and lift all our brothers and sisters towards the light.

'I have taught thee in the way of wisdom; I have led thee in right paths.'

Proverbs 4: 11

The legacy that Freemasons hope to leave is a world made just a little better, a little happier and a little wiser for their having passed through it. We do this in many ways: through our family lives, our friends, our work, our charitable activities and, of course, by making ourselves a little better, a little happier and a little wiser. But all of us have a responsibility, not only to gain and use knowledge and understanding, but to pass them on to the next generation. Whether it is to our own children by making sure they have a 'virtuous and liberal education,' or younger Brethren through precept and example, or, indeed, to younger people at large, one of the greatest gifts we can leave the world is a clear, well-trodden path that leads to personal fulfilment and peace.

'Yet now be strong, O Zerubbabel, saith the Lord; and be strong, O Joshua, son of Josedech, the high priest; and be strong, all ye people of the land, saith the Lord, and work: for I am with you, saith the Lord of hosts: '

Haggai 2:4

Having developed the discipline to listen to our inner voice, to act from our deepest sense of knowing, we have to learn to let go and trust that things will proceed as they ought. We often can't know what effect our actions will have or how they will be interpreted or acted upon by others and to try to anticipate all of those things will lead us to such uncertainty that we may stop acting altogether. We are only in control of ourselves, so if we ensure that our actions are correctly motivated, we can relax and be strong, secure in the knowledge that we have done our best.

'...may he not enter our Order lightly, nor recede from it hastily, but pursue it steadfastly...'

Ceremony of Exaltation

Entering Freemasonry is a big step and one we take largely in the dark, on trust. Once we are committed to the Craft, we tend to go through the different degree ceremonies without much thought beyond the fact that this is what comes next. When we are invited to join the Royal Arch, we can fall into the trap of doing so unconsciously, flattered to be wanted, taking the whole process a little for granted. But each step we take on the road to our own perfection is as important as the last. The Royal Arch is often referred to as the completion of the Craft Degrees but it is much more than that. It sets our feet on a whole new path. In the Craft we were led inward to discover ourselves and down into the darkness of our own mortality to learn to understand ourselves in the light of eternity. In the Royal Arch we are taken down into the darkness of this mortal life one more time in order that we might discover where light is to be found. Clearly, this is something to be undertaken consciously and pursued steadfastly.

‘Truth is One, the wise know it by many names.’

Rig Veda

In this quotation from one of the world’s oldest scriptures, the word ‘Truth’ is often inter-changed with the word ‘God.’ This deeply profound statement is of the greatest interest for every Freemason who understands that Freemasonry is loved, revered and practised by members of every religion across the globe. In many ways, Freemasonry is one of the few remaining non-denominational institutions that holds this truth as a central tenet of its identity. As Freemasons, each one of us acknowledges God but understands that every individual will conceive of God in his or her own way. To maintain this deep and broad understanding of the oneness of God, without being dragged down into sectarianism is, indeed, the mark of ‘the wise.’

‘...may he ever remember that the object of our institution is the welfare of our fellow-creatures, but above all, the honour and glory of Thy most Holy Name...’

Ceremony of Exaltation

Again, we are reminded that what we are about to do is a serious business. There is no doubt that Freemasonry can be one of the most joyous and fulfilling things we do because it satisfies us on a very deep, soulful level and this is equally and, in some senses, more true of the Royal Arch; but to glorify God – in a sense to be emissaries for all that that stands for – is a great responsibility and certainly not one to be taken lightly. We are not often given such unambiguous guidance on our purpose as Freemasons, but the message here is very clear. Let us try to remember this purpose at all times, in the Lodge and Chapter and beyond: at our festive boards, our social gatherings and in our daily lives away from the comforting and supporting presence of our Brothers and Companions.

'You have now arrived at the crown of a vaulted chamber into which it is necessary that you should descend.'

Ceremony of Exaltation

So much of the symbolism of the Royal Arch is concerned with this idea of a descent into an unknown darkness and on an esoteric level the symbolism can convey so much meaning, so many mysteries. In one sense it can stand for the Soul's descent into this mortal realm in order to learn and grow towards God. In another, it stands for the darkness of ignorance that must be plumbed to find knowledge and it can also represent that inevitable descent into the grave that awaits us all. Whatever it means to us at any given moment – and it can mean different things to each of us at different stages in our lives – there is no doubt that we must descend. No knowledge comes without experience and each of us, at some time or another, is called upon to explore our own depths, our own 'vaulted chamber.' Let us do so secure in the knowledge that help is at hand and that, at any given moment, we can be hauled to safety.

‘Let that want remind you that man by nature is a child of ignorance and error...’

Ceremony of Exaltation

It sounds rather harsh to suggest that we are children of ‘ignorance and error’ but the point being made here is that this is only the case when we are missing a vital ingredient in our make-up. Without consciousness of God, whatever we conceive that God to be, we are incomplete; we are creatures of clay lacking the vital spark that makes us fully functioning beings, able to fulfil the role assigned to us in this life, which is to work for the glory of God and the benefit of all. The darkness of the vault – the want of light – reminds us that without the light of God we are, indeed, in ignorance and error. Let us remember to walk always in the light, understanding that when we do so, we are operating from the fullness of our potential as human beings.

‘In the beginning God created the Heaven and the Earth. And the Earth was without form, and void; and the darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light, and there was light.’

Genesis 1: 1-3

These words play an important part in the Ceremony of Exaltation. They remind us that the light we seek comes from God and that, in a sense, light is the very essence of God. The words themselves remind us of this very clearly – this is the moment in the Bible story when light was created. But the scroll reminds us of more than this, too. It reassures us that we can always find answers to the questions and problems that beset us and it represents the idea that God’s will is revealed and available to us in many ways. In this sense the scroll represents the scriptures of all our religions because, as we know, Freemasonry’s truths transcend the boundaries of dogma and look to the Truth that underlies all Religion.

‘Let us therefore...walk worthily in the light which shines around.’

Ceremony of Exaltation

As Freemasons, we work with the loftiest of ideals but because we often work with them in ways that can, understandably, become overly ritualistic, we sometimes forget just how high-minded they are. It is worth remembering that many people have not yet reached the stage where they can talk easily about matters of the Spirit or where they can begin to live their lives in the light of an understanding that we are all brothers and sisters, united as one family in God. For this reason, we should try to understand ourselves, not as particularly clever or evolved or gifted, but as lucky, as blessed to be able to understand this great, all-encompassing truth.

Let us remember what a privilege it is to see the light and to walk in it. And let us always aspire to be worthy of that privilege.

‘For wisdom is better than rubies; and all the things that may be desired are not to be compared to it.’

Proverbs 8:11

In some ways, it may be said that one of the biggest steps we take as we move on from the Craft to the Royal Arch is the step from knowledge to wisdom. In the three degrees of the Craft we are encouraged to consider worldly knowledge: the hidden mysteries, the liberal arts and sciences, ourselves and our mortality. This last leads us to an understanding of our place in the light of eternity and then the Royal Arch presents us with a clear sense of our dependence on God and on the dispensation of divine Grace. This combination of knowing and understanding has the potential, when thoughtfully applied, to lead us to the wisdom that will inform our actions and sweeten all of our relationships and this, in turn, will fill all the spheres of our lives with true richness.

‘Because of thy temple at Jerusalem shall kings bring presents unto thee.’

Psalm 68:29

When we begin to live our lives in such a way that it is informed by the beliefs we profess, people are naturally attracted to us. If God is at our centre, it necessarily follows that the world will look to us for guidance, leadership and counsel. As Freemasons, we build a metaphorical Temple out of our lives and we must understand that a Temple is open to all of God’s children. This is why we aim to be strong and kind and open-hearted: because we know that we are opening a door through which the world might approach God.

'The Royal Arch...is therefore concerned with truth in the light of eternity, and so leads to a higher understanding of the purpose of our mortal existence.'

Ceremony of Exaltation

To walk through this brief life with light hearts and joyful step, knowing that all the things and people we love will come to dust, is the first step on the road to true knowledge. We know that we are mortal and yet we also hold fast to a faith in that immortal principle that guides and animates us. Knowing this and thinking logically about it make it abundantly clear that the purpose of our existence must be to concern ourselves with that which shines light on our eternal existence, not with those things that bring us merely to the brink of the grave. All material things will pass away but all those gifts and joys of the spirit will endure. It is love that lives on when all else has gone, so let us make love our currency, to spend and to share in abundance. Let us fill our days with acts that deny and defy death through generosity of heart and mind and spirit. And, by these things, let us approach that Supreme Being who is light and love and eternity.

‘In the second year of Darius the king, in the sixth month, in the first day of the month, came the word of the Lord by Haggai the prophet unto Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, and to Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest...’

Haggai 1:1

It is easy to act sometimes from impulse, without first considering the implications and possible outcomes of what we do, but it is always worth remembering that all of our actions will cause a chain of reactions that we often can't anticipate and won't see. For that reason, the more we can train ourselves to act from a deeper place of knowing and feeling, trusting our intuition and leaning on the sense of right and wrong that Freemasonry supports within us, our actions will increasingly have beneficial effects as they ripple out from us. Just as Zerubbabel and Joshua waited for the word of God through Haggai, so should we train ourselves to listen and wait for that inner voice to inspire our actions in the world.

‘...three Master Masons from Babylon, having heard that you are about to rebuild the Temple to the honour and glory of God, are anxious to sojourn among you, and to offer their assistance in that great and glorious undertaking.’

Ceremony of Exaltation

Sometimes our choices are very clear: whether it is about the right thing to do, the right path to take, or the right way to use our strength and our gifts. Which one of us would not travel through danger and difficulty to work for God, to rebuild the temple and re-establish humanity’s true relationship with its Creator? But sometimes in life our choices are not so clearly stated. Sometimes we have to ask ourselves whether this path is the right one; whether, in following it, we will be doing work that is great and glorious, however humble in the eyes of the world, or is it a path of self-serving that puts distance between us and our inner sense of what we know is right?

In all our choices and in all our decisions, let us remember to act ‘in the light of eternity.’

‘And I have filled him with the spirit of God, in wisdom, and in understanding, and in knowledge, and in all manner of workmanship...’

Exodus 31:2-4

There are many instances of wisdom and closeness to God being linked with knowledge and the craftsmanship of the maker. Through study – which may not only mean an intellectual, academic rigour but also a knowing of the heart and soul – and through creativity, we come closer to our inner selves and that means that we approach closer to God. Our role and function on earth, not just as Masons but also as human beings, is to lift the material up towards the Spiritual and bring the Spiritual down to manifest of earth. When we align ourselves with deep and honest knowing and with constructive, creative making, we begin to be channels for the spirit of God and are ready to be filled with all those gifts that will so benefit the world.

‘Humility and docility are sure indications of merit...’

Ceremony of Exaltation

It would be hard to imagine anyone putting the qualities of humility and docility on their CV when applying for a job in the modern world. They are not qualities that are valued and, more than that, they are likely to be thought of as weaknesses and worrying signs of uncertainty and vacillation. Yet, here we see them described as ‘sure indications of merit’ and, by implication, we are encouraged to cultivate them in ourselves. How can this be?

The reality is, of course, that true humility is a sign of absolute certainty in our sense of who we are and what we understand life to be. It is an indicator of total faith in the ‘wise dispensation of divine providence’ and proof that, as Masons, we see things from a wider perspective than that of mere material considerations. Docility, too, speaks of a submission to the Divine will that – to those who understand such truths – is an excellence of character to which we can all aspire.

‘My companions and I were equally anxious to descend.’

Ceremony of Exaltation

One of the great delights that Freemasonry has to offer us is the prospect of an area of personal growth and achievement that is totally free from competition and envy. As Brothers and Companions we delight in each other's successes and we encourage each other's efforts. If there are risks to be taken, we are all equally willing to take them on each other's behalf and to support each other, sharing the responsibility for subsequent failure and success.

Faced with a dark and possibly airless descent into the unknown, all three of our ancient brethren were willing to risk themselves for the benefit of all; all three of them worked together to bring their task to a successful conclusion; all three of them shared the benefit, praise and preferment that resulted. Let us take those three ancient sojourners as an example in our own lives, understanding that, by helping each other, we help ourselves and, when our efforts are directed towards the light, we help the world at large.

‘That, Most Excellent, we must humbly beg to decline...’

Ceremony of Exaltation

It takes a great deal of courage to stand up for what we believe and stay true to our own understanding of what is right and wrong. As Freemasons we are enjoined and committed to pay due regard to the laws of the lands in which we reside, but we are also obliged to obey ‘the moral law.’ So what happens when these two things clash? Luckily it is rare that this happens but if it does it can produce a conflict that is very difficult to resolve. Ultimately, there is no easy answer other than to search inside ourselves and to listen to the voice of our conscience. We are all responsible for our own actions and all subject, in the end, to higher laws that are often beyond our comprehension. To follow our own moral compass sometimes seems to be the only solution.

And how can Freemasonry help us? At least it might help us to be sure that our moral compass is properly calibrated.

‘...it was not lawful for any man to pronounce that Sacred and Mysterious name of the True and Living God Most High, but the High Priest, nor he but once a year, and then only when he entered the Holy of Holies, and stood before the Ark of the Covenant to make propitiation for the sins of the people.’

Third Degree Tracing Board

In the Craft we are led to an understanding of the sacred nature of the Name of God, a word once believed to be so powerful that to pronounce it in the wrong circumstances could reduce the speaker to ashes.

In the Royal Arch, we begin to learn what that name might be and, although further knowledge will be added later, we are taught to appreciate that this is a new step in our relationship with our Creator and that everything we learn in the Royal Arch is designed to cement that relationship further. Ultimately, for us, the name becomes a symbol of our growing closeness to God and our increasing appreciation of the way in which our lives unfold towards the bearer of that name in the same way that a flower unfolds towards the sun.

'...emblems of that purity of heart and rectitude of conduct which should always actuate all those who are exalted into this Supreme Order.'

Ceremony of Exaltation

On entering Freemasonry, we are likened to a rough ashlar, lacking education and knowledge. As we progress through the Craft we become refined, our understanding grows and we aim to become perfect ashlar, ready to be used in the building of a great temple to the glory of God. A perfect building stone has perfect dimensions and conforms perfectly to the architect's plans. A perfect human being is one who perfectly reflects the Great Architect's plans for the world and that, as we know, is one who most ably brings into being the virtues of faith, hope and love. By the time we have descended into the vaulted chamber and found the light of God by which we are to live, we hope to be in the position of being able to commit ourselves to those high ideals.

‘...there are three epochs in the history of Freemasonry which particularly merit your attention. They are, the openings of the First or Holy Lodge, the Second or Sacred Lodge, and the Third or Grand and Royal Lodge.’

Historical Lecture

In Masonic terms, these three historical events mark significant moments in our understanding of the Divine and of our relationship with God. The first Lodge relates to the time of Moses and the giving of Law. This is often cited as the moment when organised society came into being, with a set of codified laws and an agreed, shared morality. The second Lodge relates to the building of the first Temple in Jerusalem – the subject of Craft Freemasonry – and may be seen, not only as the beginning of formal worship of God in a set place but also as a time of a falling away, when our secrets were lost and we were left to contemplate a universe in which God was distant and we were no longer able to receive the light that came from above. And the third Lodge represents rediscovery and renewal; a reaffirmation of faith; a rebuilding of God’s Temple and a rediscovery of God’s word.

‘...and from this, the strongest of all architectural forms, we learn the necessity of guarding our Mysteries from profanation...’

Symbolical Lecture

The catenarian arch is one that is associated with all sorts of esoteric speculation and symbolism. It is considered to be the strongest because all the forces at work within it are perfectly balanced. In the Royal Arch, we also consider it to be a fitting symbol of what we are and what we do. The form of the Chapter itself is meant to reflect its perfect symmetry and, symbolically, we are called upon to demonstrate its inviolate strength in keeping our mysteries unsullied. It is interesting to note here that secrecy itself is not the issue; it is the idea of ensuring that our rites and ceremonies are restricted to those who will respect and preserve them. There is a verse in the New Testament which enjoins the same thing: *“Do not give what is holy to the dogs; nor cast your pearls before swine, lest they trample them under their feet, and turn and tear you in pieces.”* (Matthew 7:6)

‘Understand that as the mighty wind, blowing everywhere, rests always in the sky, all created beings rest in Me.’

Bhagavad Gita 9:6

Freemasonry provides us with a framework in which we can pursue our public and private lives with success and satisfaction. We can walk the paths of this world secure in our faith, happy that we are aiming to make our lives meaningful to ourselves and to all those with whom we come in contact. When things go wrong or when we feel adrift; when we’ve gone astray and the darkness threatens to engulf us, we should remember that we walk always in God; that the Divine essence of our Creator also resides within us and that, even though we may feel lost, that Divine spark is still there, shining its light through the gloom and guiding us home, back onto the path that leads to fulfilment and peace.

'When a man finds his path, heaven is kind.'

Anon.

One of the great things that Freemasonry can do for us is to provide pointers on the road of life that help to keep us on the right path. Although it is up to each of us to find our own way and to discover our own truths and our own sense of what is right for us and our connections, there is no doubt that Freemasonry can provide a framework that helps keep us within due bounds: with ourselves, our connections and with God. Life can often be difficult and the way sometimes is not that clear, but if we use the tools that the Craft and Royal Arch put at our disposal, we will find that it becomes more easily visible, more easy to tread and more joyful to follow to the end.

‘The three greater lights represent the Sacred Name itself, and the triune essence of the Deity; and are emblematical of His creative, preservative, and annihilative powers.’

Symbolical Lecture

It is quite rare that we see this articulation of God’s nature into three distinct powers. The idea of God as three-in-one is not uncommon and the strength and sense of the rightness of the idea of the Trinity is reflected a great deal in the Royal Arch. Here, three travel, seek and find and three rule. Interestingly, the three attributes of the Godhead outlined here are widely recognised in Hinduism where the divine essence of Brahman is expressed and known through the three deities of Brahma – the Creator, Vishnu – the Preserver and Shiva – the Destroyer.

How wonderful to be given this glimpse of the Universality of the truths to which we subscribe. Let us consider for a moment that great truth that Freemasonry is, indeed, spread around the globe and that everywhere where its light shines, minds are illumined and lives are touched by its benevolence.

'A man to personify intelligence and understanding; a lion to represent strength and power; an ox to denote the ministration of patience and assiduity; and an eagle to indicate the promptness and celerity with which the will and pleasure of the Great I AM are always executed.'

Symbolical Lecture

There is no doubt that human beings have different attributes, talents and character traits. Some are artists or musicians, writers and physicists. Some are builders and home-makers, some are listeners, talkers; the list is as endless as it is fascinating, telling as it does the story of human development, endeavour and interest. How good it would be if we could learn to use our talents and strengths, whatever they may be, to their fullest potential. How good it would be to be able to encourage the gifts that are waiting to be realised by others. How good it would be to understand that all of our gifts, all of our strengths and talents are best used in the service of God and for the benefit of all of living creatures.

'Thus saith Cyrus king of Persia, All the kingdoms of the earth hath the Lord God of heaven given me; and he hath charged me to build him an house in Jerusalem, which is in Judah. Who is there among you of all his people? The Lord his God be with him, and let him go up.'

2 Chronicles 36:23

Sometimes the right thing to do is very clear and when that happens life seems very easy. Sometimes we envy those characters in the Bible stories because we feel that if we had God telling us what to do as clearly as they did, we wouldn't be assailed by doubts and insecurities. But life isn't like that very often so we spend much of our time scrabbling around trying to figure out the correct way to behave at any given moment, weighing up who will be affected by our actions and how. Sometimes it can all get too much.

So, every now and then, it is good to reflect on how lucky we are to have something that gives us a firm anchor in these stormy seas. Freemasonry does not provide all the answers to life's problems but it does, at least, point us in the right direction.

'...the Royal Arch signs mark in a peculiar manner the relation we bear to the Almighty, as creatures offending against His mighty will and power, yet still the adopted children of His mercy.'

Mystical Lecture

All of the signs in the Royal Arch speak to us of the humility and reverence due from a creature to its Creator. We approach our Maker on bended knee, with eyes downcast, demonstrating our weakness and fragility before the great light that burns brightly around us. But we are also mindful of the great love that supports us and lifts us; the deepest sympathy for our weaknesses and failings; the endless patience of a parent for a beloved child. Let us consider how we might always be worthy of that great love and also how we might share it and manifest it in our own lives, through our dealings with others.

‘How strained and wretched would be our life, if our hope were not so spacious and extensive!’

Mohamed Abu Alahmar (attrib.)

Life can be very difficult sometimes and it feels as if we are forever struggling in the darkness. All of our efforts as Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft and Master Mason led us to the brink of the grave and it seems that in life, too, none of our efforts will be enough to lift us from the round of our earthly existence into the realms of Light. Luckily, we have our faith and this faith naturally creates in us a hope that is directed at nothing less than the throne of God.

When things appear dark, let us remember that help is at hand: our Companions will lift us out of the airless vault and together our hopes will help us to ascend to the very summit of Jacob’s Ladder, ‘...that ethereal mansion, not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.’

'...we are taught...to bend with humility and resignation beneath the chastening hand of the Most High, and at the same time engraft his law on our heart.'

Mystical Lecture

A young man once sat at the feet of a Master and listened to the teachings that flowed from the wise one's lips. At the end of the talk all the other students bowed down in reverence but the young man could not. He did not know this teacher and was not sure that it was right to surrender himself in this way to someone he was unsure was worthy of it. When the others were gone, the teacher smiled at the young man and said, "You were right to hesitate; it is true that I, myself, am not worthy of your reverence. But when we bow before a teacher, it is the teachings we salute, not the person. We salute the Truth."

The young man prostrated himself with a clear heart and went on his way, happy.

Let us always find it in our hearts to surrender ourselves completely to the Truth, wherever we find it, knowing that God resides within it.

‘The triangle has long been considered a sacred symbol. In times of antiquity names of God and symbols of Divinity were often enclosed in triangular figures.’

Mystical Lecture

The triangle is an incredibly powerful symbol and is reflected in so much of Royal Arch ritual: the strength of three is a recurring motif. But the form of the equilateral triangle also represents the striving of humankind for God; the struggle to shift our lives from the material physicality of the wide, flat base to the spiritual unity represented by the sharp, upward-pointing apex. In some Lodges, the triangular flap of an Entered Apprentice’s apron is worn folded upwards to demonstrate that the spiritual and the physical are not fully integrated in one so new on the path. For many, the six-pointed star represents the idea that God descends to humanity as humanity strives to uplift itself towards God.

‘Prepare our hearts in sympathy to be partners in suffering with the weak; partners in eager service with the strong.’

Anon.

To be human and to be adult means making choices. As Freemasons, we have already made some very important choices about the kinds of lives we wish to lead and about the kinds of people we wish to be. But making the decision to do this or that or to be this or that is only the beginning. Now we have to do it and to be it. And that requires a daily effort to renew and reaffirm those choices. Every day we must remake the commitment to live according to our values. We have already identified ourselves as helpers and protectors of the weak; we have already committed our strength – heart, body and mind – to serve those who need it and to serve all that helps lift humanity from darkness to light. Let us prepare ourselves afresh each day for this work and let this spirit of service suffuse all our days, whatever else we do.

'The circle is an emblem of eternity, for as it is without beginning or end, it may justly be deemed emblematic of God, who is without beginning of days or end of years, and it continually reminds us of that great hereafter or futurity, where we hope to obtain eternal life.'

Mystical Lecture

The first thing we are told on becoming Master Masons is that, at last, we are able to work with both points of the compass to render the circle of our lives complete. We learn early on in our Masonic journeys that the circle is an important symbol, containing as it does a sense of absolute completeness and a centre from which we cannot err. The circles of our lives connect with the circles of all the other people with whom we come into contact, overlapping and merging as our lives touch and are touched by friends, family and the wider world. But let us remember that all of our smaller circles, with all of their endless interconnections are contained within the greater circle that is God: eternal, ineffable, the beginning and end of all.

‘On that plate of gold was the word J.H.V.H, that great, awful, tremendous and incomprehensible name of the Most High...’

Mystical Lecture

To be given a thing's true name was once thought to be given power over that thing. Between ourselves, the idea of being on 'first name terms' with someone is a sign of closeness and informality, a sign of friendship and even of intimacy. As we approach God by way of our journey through life in general and Freemasonry in particular we are led from the formality of titles like 'Great Architect,' 'Grand Geometrician' or 'Most High,' to specific names that cement our growing relationship with our Creator. But just as a man might be known by different names by different people: Mr. Smith to business associates, Robert to acquaintances and Bob to his friends, so are different names of God revealed to us as we approach closer to the divine presence. There are no contradictions here, only a growing closeness, a flowering of love.

‘Then rose up Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Jeshua the son of Jozadak, and began to build the house of God which is at Jerusalem: and with them were the prophets of God helping them.’

Ezra 5: 1-3

One of the wonderful things about Freemasonry is its practicality, the power it has to inform our daily lives and make a difference to the ways in which we act and the ways in which we relate to others. But life isn't just about doing. When we act we must do so from a core of thinking and feeling so that our actions arise from our thoughts, our dreams, our aspirations. The fact that those practical men who rebuilt the Temple were supported and helped by the prophets of God can stand as a reminder that all of our doing, all of our making, all of our manifesting on the outer planes of life should arise from an inner impulse that has God as its centre.

'It shows the Royal Arch to be the climax of Freemasonry...It has virtue for its aim, the glory of God for its object, and the eternal welfare of man is considered in every part...'

Mystical Lecture

The idea that the Royal Arch completes the journey of Freemasonry may be taken to mean many things. One clear sense is the idea that Craft Freemasonry leads us to explore ourselves: our physical limitations, our relationships in this world; even encouraging us to consider how this world works and how far human knowledge may take us in comprehending it. But all of this knowledge leads us to the grave and the third degree points clearly to the fact that, if we want to understand what happens beyond that grave, we need to look higher, beyond the reflected light of our world, described merely as darkness visible, into the true light of divinity.

When we begin to understand ourselves in relation to God, we begin to understand the true depths of what we are.

Let us remember the truth of our divine origins and let the eternal welfare of all become our natural concern.

‘Do you promise to administer justice with impartiality, to reprove the disobedient with firmness, and not to forget that Mercy is one of the attributes of Him to whom our Institution is dedicated?’

Installation of ‘J’

The learning curve in the Royal Arch is quite steep. There are fewer rungs on the ladder that leads to the principal offices and, in one sense, this is how it should be. The slow, incremental learning of the Craft can be accelerated now as our knowledge becomes more rarefied and single-minded. What is immediately obvious here is that as soon as we take higher office in the Chapter, we are tacitly reminded that as we approach nearer to God, we are called upon to take on more spiritual qualities ourselves and rule impartially, as does the One who is our example in all things. Thus justice and mercy are enjoined upon us from the moment that we are given the power to exercise them.

'I must, however, impress upon your mind that the higher the rank to which you are elevated, the more important and responsible do the duties required of you become.'

Installation of 'Z'

This is true in any walk of life: rank brings responsibility and the higher our position, the greater the burden placed upon us. It is true that in the world we are often rewarded for our responsibility as well, which helps us to bear the burden, but in Freemasonry a different value system applies. In the Royal Arch we all make the commitment to come to terms with our relationship with God. As rulers in the Chapter, there is an added responsibility to personify and emulate exalted characters who formally took on the responsibility to lead our ancestors on this path of knowing. We are first Priest, then Prophet, then Prince and all of these roles carry heavy responsibility without any reward save that truly Masonic one of knowing that when the job is done, it is well done.

‘...whilst we are labouring to erect and preserve our earthly tabernacle to Thy Name and Glory, we may at the same time prepare our path to Thy eternal Temple, where peace and glory reign for ever...’
Installation of ‘Z’

There does not need to be any separation of our lives into spiritual and material; into worship and our daily labour. We are taught as Entered Apprentices that we should divide our time appropriately, but by the time we have advanced to the Royal Arch, the various strands that make us human are much more closely integrated and so we can begin to see our lives and actions in a more unified way. We labour on Earth for the benefit of our fellow travellers and for the glory of God. If our work is well-directed and our actions well-motivated, we should understand that this is spiritual work too. We recognise that the way to the ‘eternal Temple’ lies not in separation from the mundane and physical, but in the elevation of the mundane and physical to acts of service and prayer. Let us not lose sight of the fact that all of life is a spiritual journey and that, as Master Masons, we are qualified to work with the full circle of our lives.

‘The crown...being an emblem of sovereignty, should remind you that to reign in the hearts and affections of the Companions is far more gratifying to a generous mind than to rule over their lives and fortunes.’

Address to ‘Z’

Although the original Zerubbabel was a Prince who wielded earthly power, we, as his symbolic descendents and imitators do not do so. Power, as held by the rulers in Freemasonry is nothing to do with temporal power, but our rulers are still important to us. In the Royal Arch they not only represent the characters whose names they bear, but also our highest aspirations and hopes. As such, we readily open our hearts to them, looking always for the best that a human being can be and for worthy examples to follow on the path we all tread. The rulers, being gifted these open hearts, take on a huge responsibility to hold them lightly and to treat them reverently, understanding that an open heart is a rare and most precious trust.

‘...we learn that the Almighty does not look upon the outward appearance of a man, but upon the heart.’

Installation of ‘Z’

When we set our feet on the path of Freemasonry, although we may not realise it at first, we take a direction that diverges in many subtle ways from the path of modern society. Freemasons are not part of a religious sect that hides itself away from the world or shuns it in any way. We live in the world and there are even those among us who do so prominently and in the public eye but, at the same time, we are proud to align ourselves more and more with those aspects of society that look beyond surface values to those that are found in the deeper vaults and recesses of the human heart. As ever, we do our best to look upon ourselves, each other and the wider world with the eyes of eternity and see each other as God sees us.

‘...and to preserve that bond of union and fraternal love which has ever been the foundation of the Masonic structure.’

Installation of ‘Z’

Like all of the relationships in our lives, those with our Brethren and Companions in our Lodges and Chapters need to be constantly worked on to maintain their lustre. It is easy to slip into bad habits; to become critical or negative; to repeat gossip; to speak unkindly of someone. It is good to remember that, not only have we taken solemn obligations to see and encourage the best in each other, but that to do so is also to cement our relationships further with that Masonic mortar which is brotherly love. And now, as our Companion is prepared to take the highest office in the Chapter, he – and we with him – is reminded that this brotherly love is the bedrock upon which the whole structure of Freemasonry rests. How important, then, do all our relationships become when seen from this perspective! Let us commit ourselves to do all we can to support each other to be the very best we can be at all times – in and out of the Temple.

‘...an example of that moral rectitude of conduct which alone can entitle him to the goodwill and affection of the Companions, and the respect and homage due to the office.’

Installation of ‘Z’

Promotion and responsibility go hand in hand and as we climb the ladder of office through Lodge and Chapter we cannot help but realise the increasing weight of history that we bear on our shoulders as we become the focus of the aspirations of our Brethren. It is only fair that there should be some separation in the minds of all between the Office and the holder of that Office, but it cannot be denied that our personal conduct and our standing with our Brethren and Companions affects the way they relate to the Offices we hold. It can be seen, therefore, that our responsibilities begin much earlier than our first step on that ladder. From our entry into Freemasonry, we are building a foundation upon which our later effectiveness as rulers is being constantly built and, from the earliest moments of our Masonic lives, we are responsible for preserving the dignity and respect due to the rulers of our Order.

‘But Zerubbabel, and Jeshua, and the rest of the chief of the fathers of Israel, said unto them, Ye have nothing to do with us to build an house unto our God; but we ourselves together will build unto the Lord God of Israel, as king Cyrus the king of Persia hath commanded us.’

Ezra 4:3

The whole question of inclusion and exclusion is one that we need to consider. We are, in many ways, an open group insofar as we welcome new members and enquiries from those interested our rites and customs. We are also closed in the sense that those rites and customs are really only available to those who have joined us. It’s something of a contradiction and one we should be aware of. Exclusion without sensitivity can lead to bad feeling and alienation; inclusion without discernment can lead to a dilution of what we are. As ever, we must aim to walk a middle way, dealing with each situation as it arises and judging it on its own merits.

‘Grant that our labours may produce the fruits of wisdom and love;’

Installation of ‘Z’

It is an obvious truth that if you want to grow a particular plant, you must plant the right seeds. You can prepare the earth and weed and water as carefully as you like, but if you wanted carrots but sowed pumpkin seeds, you are bound to be disappointed. In the same way, the excellences of character that we aim to cultivate do not come about by accident. We direct our labour – our actions, both physical and mental – in certain ways and we understand that wisdom and love will be the fruits that we will reap at the end. Indeed, the whole purpose of Freemasonry is to direct us towards those seeds which need to be planted in our lives in order to attain this rich and benevolent harvest. Our words and actions are seeds. Let us aim to produce the best and most worthwhile of fruits.

‘The passages of Scripture just read afford ample proof of His readiness and power to assist those who love, fear, and obey Him.’

Installation of ‘H’

Although the details of each Mason’s faith are private and personal, all of us have openly professed our belief in the existence of a Supreme Being. As we have progressed through Freemasonry’s initiatory pathways, we have come to accept that the nature of that Being is Love. As Companions we have also all seen and acknowledged the darkness and the depths and we have descended into the vault to bring forth the light of God’s word. We should remember that moment as being one of profound symbolical importance because it was the moment that we realised our potential as instruments of God’s plan, for we enacted the fact of our ability to contribute by bringing light into the world. And when we come into line with God’s plan, we can be sure that help and assistance will be there for us.

‘It is the best proof that your conduct as a Master and your zeal as a mason are approved and acknowledged by the Companions.’

Installation of ‘J’

Eventually, most Companions will have the opportunity to fill the roles of Principals in their Chapter and, eventually, even the youngest Chapters will have a great many Past Principals in their ranks. This should in no way lessen the sense of honour or importance of the role. Freemasonry is structured in such a way that we are properly prepared for all the positions of responsibility that we undertake, if we only listen to and observe the lessons that are presented to us. When we are given offices in our Lodges and Chapters, we should understand that these are honours bestowed on us because we have proved ourselves worthy of them. Let us always seek to learn the lessons that come our way and to prepare ourselves as well as we can for the weight and the gift of leadership.

‘...at your initiation into Freemasonry you were recommended to study the V.S.L. as a guide to your faith, and I trust that, during the progress you have made in the different degrees of the Order, you have adhered to that recommendation.’

Installation of ‘J’

In the first Degree we learn that our ascent to the ‘summit of Freemasonry’ is enabled by a ladder – Jacob’s Ladder. The rungs are made up of all the moral virtues, the three principal ones being Faith, Hope and Love. The foundation of the ladder, the base on which it rests, is the Volume of the Sacred Law – the word of God. This sense that we are God’s creatures and servants, subject to the Divine will that is revealed through scripture is a crucial tenet of Freemasonry and one that runs from the lowest to the highest degrees of our Order. Learning to understand and live by the Sacred revelations that we have been given – whatever our particular Religion or belief – is a process that never ends. There is always more to discover and there are always choices we can make to become better human beings and better Masons.

'Vouchsafe to us that mercy which Thou didst not withhold from Thine ancient people, so that, at the close of this, our mortal career, we may be numbered among those who shall be admitted into Thy temple of eternal bliss and glory.'

Installation of 'J'

Freemasonry is a path of action, of doing. We live and work in the world and are in no way separate from it. Freemasonry gives us an added framework within which to act and it provides a guide as to how best to live our lives to their full advantage – to ourselves and to all of those who come within our compass. In the Craft we are taught to live compassionate and generous lives in service to the greater good, understanding that the path of Faith, Hope and Charity leads to a greater life beyond this one. In the Royal Arch we are checked a little because now we must contemplate the truth that our own actions can only take us so far along the path. Without God's mercy in meeting us at least halfway, we are too weak to climb to the summit. Let us remember that and tread our individual paths with due humility and gratitude.

'To that end you must subdue all passions and prejudices, and cultivate charity; not to Companions alone but to all mankind.'

Address to 'Z'

Charity is love in action and charity in its most exalted sense is love. When we are called upon to cultivate charity, it is not an appeal to give in a material sense but it is a call to us to put all that we have learned with regard to our true relationship with God and with each other into the practice of our daily lives. To see and empathise with the burdens of others, to succour their weakness, relieve their distress and, yes, to give material aid where appropriate are all acts of charity; to lend a sympathetic ear and listen with an understanding heart; to care, unselfishly, for others are all signs of a good Freemason. And let us remember always that this charity, this love in action, must go beyond the bounds of our Masonic connections if it is to be truly Masonic.

‘...the harmony of the Chapter should be your constant care; and as the glorious sun, when at its meridian, dispels the mists and clouds which obscure the horizon, so may your exertions dissipate the gloom of jealousy and discord should it ever appear.’

Address to ‘H’

All of us have a responsibility to maintain a harmonious atmosphere in the Lodge or Chapter. Indeed, it is impossible to imagine that any Masonic business could be conducted without it. But it is true that the more prominent a role we take in the Order, the more important our own individual demeanour becomes. Again, we must contemplate the relationship between authority and responsibility but we should also be reassured that we do have within us the power to dispel any unwholesome influences and that through our conscious exertions, the light of reason, truth and brotherhood may be brought to bear on any discord or darkness.

‘It...is peculiarly characteristic of our Order, which has stood the test of ages and is distinguished by the beauty of its superstructure, namely universal brotherhood and benevolence.’

Address to ‘J’

The blue vault of heaven, in all its beauty, is used as a simile to describe the beauty of the Masonic structure. Just as the sky is always there to delight our hearts whenever we remember to lift our eyes towards the heights, so is the superstructure of Freemasonry always there to fill us with peace and a sense of rightness when we remember to pull ourselves away from the cares of daily life that so often threaten to engulf us. To dwell for just a moment in that gentle ocean of universal brotherhood and benevolence is to immerse ourselves in the truth of what we are and all that we aspire to be. And it is so close! When we reach up, we touch the sky; and when we think of these deeper truths, they come into being within us.

Let us make a commitment to think of them for at least a moment every day.

‘It is intended to remind you that in the breast of a Freemason those virtues should be as expansive and all embracing as the blue vault of Heaven.’

Address to ‘J’

It is hard to imagine that our hearts can encompass such a wide-reaching and complete comprehension of the virtues that Masonry expounds. But we all know that the last and greatest of all these virtues is love and that the Mason who is in full possession of that virtue has attained the summit of Freemasonry. And so our hearts expand to encompass this great love, this great sense of compassion and charity towards all living creatures. As we are raised out of the darkness by those who stand beside us, we not only reveal the light but we are filled with it ourselves and we become instruments of that divine plan which bids us manifest true brotherhood here on earth.

‘...impress your mind with a sense of your dependence upon God, and that perfection is not vouchsafed unto man upon earth, perfect holiness appertaining only unto the Lord.’

Address to ‘J’

It’s something of a brake on our progress when we are confronted with the idea that our own efforts will never be enough for us to attain the perfection to which we aspire. In the Craft we were encouraged, through intellectual study and contemplation and through good works, to aim for the peaks of love and compassion, the summit of Jacob’s ladder, and it led us only to the brink of a figurative grave. Now, in the Royal Arch, we are taught to look towards God to provide us with the wherewithal to ascend those final rungs, for beyond the visible extent of the ladder lie further, higher realms that can only be reached through God’s grace. Let us remember our dependence and use that remembering to deal more compassionately, more humbly, with the struggles and aspirations of all with whom we come into contact.

‘Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding.’

Proverbs 4:7

Wisdom can be defined in many ways. It is not the same as knowledge and yet it clearly involves knowing. One definition of wisdom says it is the ‘ability to discern or judge what is true, right, or lasting’ and to do that we must have some sense of knowing what is true and what is right. Perhaps wisdom is the correct application of a certain type of knowledge: knowledge of things of the spirit and of eternity, rather than the material ephemera with which we are bombarded. As Companions, we have been lowered into the depths of material darkness and we have found that the word of God is what brings illumination. That is a high level of knowledge. If we now apply that knowledge meaningfully in our lives, that is the beginning of wisdom.

‘We have the fullest confidence in you, and believe that you will do your utmost for the comfort and prosperity of the Chapter.’

Investiture of Treasurer

That Freemasonry encourages us to be the best we can be is something that is clear from our earliest steps on the path. But sometimes we can miss the subtler messages and positive affirmations contained in the most seemingly unimportant pieces of ritual. By the time we take office in the Chapter, we are far along the road and our commitment and ability are proven. How lovely that this investiture – and the others that take place alongside it – express such heartfelt confidence in our abilities. How reassuring it is to be ‘seen’ to have it known that we are competent and that our motivation to continue along our chosen path is without reproof. Let us do all that we can to continue to make that so.

'You should make yourselves perfect in the work which falls to him, so that in the event of your being called upon to fill his place you may do so with credit to the Chapter.'

Investiture of Assistant Sojourners

We are usually so caught up in the work we have to do in the Chapter that we can easily forget that there are others working just as hard. It is interesting here that those with less to do are enjoined to be ready to stand in, should another Companion be unable to fulfil his role. This is another example of how Freemasonry readies us gently for the offices and responsibilities that lie ahead of us but it also has wider implications. The idea that we should always be ready to step in to support or stand in for another is a very profound one. It forces us to be aware of them, of their work, their role, their place in our lives. It acknowledges without fuss our interdependence and the truth that we are stronger when united. Let us always be ready to step in to help another and to stand for them when needed. Let us trust that they will do the same for us.

'...but the public reputation of the Institution will be found generally to rise or fall as the character and conduct of its principal officers are estimable or censurable.'

Charge to the Principals

The days of Masonic secrecy are – thankfully – over. It is no longer the norm for a Mason's family and connections to be unaware of their affiliation, indeed such a state of affairs would be unusual and strange in this day and age. There is no benefit in being a member of something we are embarrassed about, so our choices are to withdraw or to make it our business – by our behaviour, our relationships, by all our actions – to show the world that Freemasonry is something we take pride in and that it is worthy of our time and attention. The higher our position in Freemasonry the truer this becomes, but it is true of all of us. Let us remember, then, that beyond our circle of personal connections, our conduct matters in ways that we sometimes do not see and to people whom we do not always know. The world watches us – often with suspicion. Let us do all we can to reassure the world that we are a force for good.

'You are to see that your officers are capable and faithful in the discharge of their respective offices. Should they lack ability you are expected to remedy their defects.'

Charge to the Principals

It's always easy to be disparaging of another's weaknesses and it's easy to take a position where one feels superior. How disturbing it is to be told that we are responsible for the shortcomings of our Companions! But how beautiful it is to be reminded of our unity and of the importance of the work we do together! In the Lodge and Chapter and out in the wider world, we are responsible for each other and – without detriment to ourselves or connections – we are committed to help lift all of humanity out of darkness and bring them towards the light. If we are further ahead on the path, we are no better than others: it is only time that is the difference between us and them. We got to where we are with the help and guidance of others and we continue to progress because of it. Now it is our turn to help those behind us and smooth their way as much as we are able.

'It also strongly typifies that invariable adherence to social order and the spirit of fraternal union which has ever given energy and permanence to the whole constitution of Freemasonry, thereby enabling it to survive the wreck of mighty empires, and to resist the destroying hand of time.'

Symbolical Lecture

Once again, we are called upon to consider the strength and symbolism of the catenarian arch. Interestingly, the word derives from the Latin word for 'chain' and we are immediately reminded of the symbolism contained in that lovely piece of ritual, given at many festive boards, The Entered Apprentice Chain. With the links of the chain, and the stones of the arch, a key understanding is that every link, every stone is vital to the strength of the whole. And while there is much symbolism to be derived from the keystone of the catenarian arch, for the moment let us just consider our interdependence, the fraternal bonds that link us as a chain around the globe, not only with our fellow Masons but with all of our Brothers and Sisters in the wider human family.

‘Companions in Office, precept and example should ever advance at an equal pace. Those moral duties which you are required to teach to others you should never neglect to practise yourselves.’
Charge to the Officers

‘Practice what you preach’ is a well-known guard against hypocrisy and we all understand that to say one thing and do another renders a person untrustworthy and a source of instability to their connections. But it should not just be seen as a negative admonition because it is also a positive affirmation of a deep truth. To explain something well we have to understand it fully and to understand something fully we have to have experienced its truth for ourselves. So let us take this as a gentle reminder to be in a position of knowing before we attempt to teach. Let us remember that we must be willing to learn and practise all that we would like to share with others.

‘May your Chapter become beautiful as the Temple of King Solomon, sacred as its most Holy Place and peaceful as the Ark which it enshrines.’

Charge to the Officers

What a beautiful thought! That our Chapters should be so blessed with beauty and holiness and peace. Is it possible? And what does it mean?

Yes, it is possible – but only through our own endeavours. What we do in the Chapter; how we behave towards each other; the solemnity we bring to our rituals and the joy with which we enact them will bring all of these things among us.

What was it that made the Temple so beautiful; the Holy Place so sacred; the Ark such a source of peace? The answer to all three questions is the same: the Presence of God.

To make God present among us is a simple thing: act with sincerity and with love; embody those truly Masonic virtues of Faith, Hope and Charity and the Spirit of God will be with us, in the Lodge, in the Chapter and in our hearts, wherever we go.

This small inscription, to be found (after careful search) on the Royal Arch jewel is, perhaps, the clearest and most profound statement of what it is to be a Freemason. It is translated in the explanation of the jewel as: 'A worshipper of God and a citizen of the world.' And this, quite simply is what we are. When all else is washed away; when all the things that can divide and separate us and set us against each other are gone, this is what we are. No creed or colour, no religion or race; no sexuality or nationality, no tribe or clan or political persuasion: we worship God and we are citizens of the world: kin to all; brothers to all; and we work for the good of all.

‘The Circle is an Emblem of Eternity. The equilateral triangle point upwards is a symbol of Fire, and as the flames rise this represents the aspirations of man to higher things; the equilateral triangle point downwards is a symbol of Water – Dew, the Grace of God falling on all mankind. Thus we have Man’s Aspirations and God’s Grace all within the Circle of Eternity;’

Presentation of Supreme Grand Chapter Certificate

Again we are reminded that while we can aspire to reach the heights, we can only fully achieve them by being met halfway by the Grace of God descending to us. This lovely symbol of the fire in our hearts, burning for the Divine, and the cooling balm of the dew descending from Heaven should awake in us an awareness of our role as sharers with God of the responsibilities of being human. We are made to look upwards, to progress from the material to the spiritual but at the same time we are here to manifest God on earth. What is spirit helps lifts us up and what is physical helps God come down. It is a profound thought and a weighty responsibility but within the eternal circle we are held secure.

‘They gave money also unto the masons, and to the carpenters; and meat, and drink, and oil, unto them of Zidon, and to them of Tyre, to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to the sea of Joppa, according to the grant that they had of Cyrus king of Persia.’

Ezra 3:7

It’s nice to think that we have some sort of connection – even if it’s a symbolical one – with those ancient masons who helped rebuild the Temple in Jerusalem. It’s also interesting to note the number of different people involved in the labour besides the masons: from Cyrus himself to the administrators that must have been needed, to the sailors and woodsmen and carpenters. If we are to learn anything from this, let it remind us that we never work alone. Imagine a Temple built of stone alone: no cloth for the floors and walls, no ornaments for the Holy of Holies, no metal artefacts or ornaments. We need others around us just as they need us around them. All of us, everywhere across the globe, are connected in a web of interdependence. Let us determine to use this interconnectedness positively.

'Even God cannot change the past.'

Agathon (attrib.)

On the one hand, whatever lies behind us is done and finished with, but on the other, what has gone before defines and shapes us and is what has made us what we are. All of our deeds, good and bad, live on in the echoes and repercussions they had – and have – in the lives of those who were affected by them. As Freemasons, we are encouraged to always look forward, to raise our eyes to the heavens and direct our steps on paths that will lead us to our avowed destination: a life lived in ever greater appreciation of our relationship with our Creator and in greater harmony with the world around us. None of us can change the past but all of us can determine to create a more hopeful future.

*'Here's a health to all those that we love,
Here's a health to all those that love us,
Here's a health to all those that love them that love those
That love them that love those that love us.'*

Anon

As we make the conscious effort to live lives that are kinder, more gentle, more considerate; more conscious of our Creator and our fellow creatures, we come more and more into loving relationships with those around us. We soften and grow and learn to value that warmth of brotherhood that is the key to our enjoyment of Freemasonry. And the great thing is that love, by its nature, spreads and grows the more it is acknowledged and invoked so that, if we wish, with very little effort on our part, we can find ourselves at the centre of an ever-widening circle of love that will support and hold us; and we can know that the same is true for the circle of our friends and connections. What a great gift to bring to the world!

*'Hierusalem, my happy home,
When shall I come to thee?
When shall my sorrows have an end,
Thy joys when shall I see? '*

Anon.

As Freemasons, we profess a belief in God – whatever we conceive that God to be – and our belief creates in us a hope that beyond this mortal life there lies another, greater, more real existence. Whatever that other existence proves to be, we can only express it now in terms of the ideals that we hold and the limited idea of perfection that is available to us in our current, imperfect state. The Temple that we build of our lives on earth may have its foundations planted on the ground of this reality but, as we build, we do what we can to ensure that its heights will reach beyond this life into that great hope of futurity. And so we build, not just for our present concerns, but also for our anticipated future in a holy city only hinted at by this earthly Jerusalem.

'The nature of God is a circle of which the centre is everywhere and the circumference is nowhere.'

Anon.

This is an image that should please every Freemason. We are taught to consider the idea that our 'lost secrets' are to be found with the centre but it is never fully explained what that centre is. We know it is a point from which we can act without error but what is it, really, in our lives? We can begin to understand the concept by thinking that the centre is our innermost self but from there we need to consider the idea that at the centre of our innermost self is God. To understand that the circle is God and is therefore everything in our lives and our world, is to begin to approach the truth. The circle is so all-encompassing, so vast, that the point that is its centre is already everything we can conceive of; therefore its limits, its outer edge or circumference is so far beyond our understanding as to be nowhere in so far as we can comprehend it. To meditate on this image is to let your mind expand to the very limits of human consciousness and, perhaps for a moment, to touch the infinite.

'We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal.

American Declaration of Independence

Some things are so obvious that we think they don't need saying. And yet some truths are so important, so overwhelmingly central to the way we understand ourselves and the world around us that they must be stated and repeated so that they become totally assimilated into what we are. Sometimes things are so obvious that we don't say them enough and then we forget them, or at least forget their importance.

So let us state again, and remember it in our lives and make its truth self-evident in the way we interact with everybody with whom we come into contact: we believe absolutely that all human beings are the children of God and that we live with them as brothers and sisters, over, above and beyond any Masonic connection. If we are Brothers to our fellow Masons, we are, surely, Brothers to all.

‘From the gods comes the saying, ‘Know thyself.’

Juvenal

In the ceremony of exaltation, we are led, eventually, to an understanding that our ultimate task is to realise our true relationship with our Creator. We are not asked to do this by trying to understand God’s nature fully because it is a given that we are not able to conceive of it in anything other than very simple terms. This is why we approach with head bowed and eyes shielded. However, we can come to an understanding of God through an understanding of ourselves and it is for this reason that we are lowered into the darkness that represents the human condition to find God’s word, through which we are once more restored to the light of knowledge. In coming to know ourselves, we step ever closer towards the source of that light and we trust that, one day, we will be provided with the tools we need to render our knowledge complete.

‘If a man will begin with certainties, he shall end in doubts; but if he will be content to begin with doubts, he shall end in certainties.’

Francis Bacon

Sometimes knowing can be an impediment on the road to true understanding. When we are sure we know something, we close our minds to the possibility that there may be yet more to comprehend. But if we approach with an open mind and an open heart, willing to listen, willing to adopt a more humble demeanour, we may learn more than we could have imagined. Freemasonry always offers more lessons, deeper insights and the possibility of ever greater levels of understanding and we must be sure to stay open to this great gift that the Order offers to us. It is for this reason that we are encouraged ‘to make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge.’ Those who suggest that this injunction only applies to the learning of ritual have already closed themselves off from the infinite possibilities that deeper study might afford them. Let us determine to remain open, to allow a level of doubt in our knowing and to trust all the while that this will lead, in the end, to certainty.

‘But men must know, that in this theatre of man’s life it is reserved only for God and angels to be lookers on.’

Francis Bacon

One thing that can be said about Freemasonry is that we understand that our task on earth is to build; and that what we build is a Temple to the glory of God. But, of course, the Temple is a metaphorical one and what we actually build are good lives and good relationships. What is important, though, is that we act; that we actually do something constructive to bring about that better world that we believe is both possible and natural for us. We are not onlookers here; these are our lives, our friends, our families, our brothers and sisters across the world whose lives can be touched and bettered by our actions. In becoming Freemasons, we made a conscious acknowledgement of our interconnectedness with all of God’s children and now it is up to us to act in such a way as to demonstrate that fact in a way that improves the lives of those around us. We don’t need to be world leaders to do this, we just need to be the best that we can be with those within our circle, however small and humble.

‘This knowledge is the king of education, the most secret of all secrets. It is the purest knowledge, and because it gives direct perception of the self by realization, it is the perfection of religion.’

Bhagavad Gita 9:2

Freemasonry is a lot of fun. In fact, many Masons will tell you that they are only in it for the fun they have. Even promotional literature from Grand Lodge aimed at recruiting new members suggests that Freemasonry is worth joining because it is fun. But ‘fun’ is not at the core of what we are. Ultimately, we are on a quest for the deepest and most profound knowledge to which human beings can aspire: the knowledge of ourselves. We do have fun along the way and much of the enjoyment we find is a reflection of the fact that we are treading a ‘true’ path which brings joy to the human spirit, as well as the fact that we tread the path with like-minded Companions. Let us determine to make the effort to look beyond the surface attractions of Freemasonry to find its hidden core of knowledge and truth.

‘All good moral philosophy is but an handmaid to religion.’

Francis Bacon

There is so much about Freemasonry that is positive and good. Look how it encourages us to be better people and to see our fellow human beings as brothers and sisters. Look at the charitable work that we do; look how we encourage fellow feeling, how we encourage learning and contemplation and the sense of community. There is so much of which we can be proud and there is so much that we can show to the world and say, ‘Look, this is what we are.’

But to just look at this and to think that this is all we are is to miss the point. All of these things are true but they are only given validity and depth by the fact that we have as our central tenet, our most important Landmark, the belief in God. Without this belief we are just another social and charitable organisation – not that there is anything wrong with being ‘just’ that – but we are much deeper. Our moral philosophy is underpinned by true religion: love of God and of our neighbour.

‘If a man be gracious and courteous to strangers, it shows he is a citizen of the world.’

Francis Bacon

To be kind to all is the mark of a person who feels comfortable with their own humanity and who is secure in the knowledge that they are no better or worse than anyone else in the world, however seemingly different their background or position, their education, religion or culture. We understand what it means to consider ourselves ‘on the level’ with each other within the confines of Freemasonry, but to understand that we are on the level with all of humanity is a further step towards a fuller appreciation of our place and role in the world. As Freemasons, this should be how the world sees us and how we should interact with the world: with grace and courtesy, so that all the world will know that to be a Freemason is to be gentle and thoughtful, selfless and caring, a true citizen of the world.

‘Then Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest, with all the remnant of the people, obeyed the voice of the Lord their God, and the words of Haggai the prophet, as the Lord their God had sent him, and the people did fear before the Lord.’

Haggai 1:12

To say that the Royal Arch asks us to consider our relationship with God in greater depth is undoubtedly true, but it also asks us to listen more closely to our inner selves and to align ourselves more closely with our own soul. Acting from this deep core of knowing and feeling and intuition, from this deep sense of rightness, cannot help but make our lives, and the lives of those around us, happier and more full of light. But if we hear this voice, or feel this intuition, and then ignore it, it is worse than not hearing it in the first place because we bend ourselves out of shape, doing what does not feel right and what does not accord with our innermost selves. Zerubbabel and Joshua would not ignore the word of God. Nor must we.

'God help all poor souls lost in the dark.'

Robert Browning

We enter the world from the darkness of the womb; we enter Freemasonry hoodwinked and in the dark. At our Raising we face the darkness of death and are told that even the light by which we see the world is but 'darkness visible.' Metaphorically, darkness symbolises ignorance and we accept that for much of our lives we grope blindly, not knowing who or what we are. In the Royal Arch we finally face the darkness that surrounds us and we descend knowingly and willingly into the vault. We are rewarded by the discovery of the light of God's word and we then bring this light back into the world. As we share our discovery, we come slowly to understand that we are all 'poor souls lost in the dark' and that God is our only help.

Let us determine to remember the source of light in our lives and, more importantly, to share that understanding and so help to bring illumination and enlightenment to all.

*'Through such souls alone
God stooping shows sufficient of His light
For us i' the dark to rise by. And I rise.'*

Robert Browning

The six-pointed star in Freemasonry hints at our understanding that, as we reach up to God, so God comes down to meet us and lift us higher. All over the world, in every culture and religious tradition there are stories told of those who have given their lives to help illumine the way for others. When we recognise the help that is thus offered, it would be foolish to refuse, especially now that we have made a commitment to raise ourselves up in this way. But having taken a few faltering steps along the path, we must be aware that while there are those ahead, helping us, there are also those behind whom we could help. And, though we might not feel qualified to do so, we must understand that we, too, through the understanding that Freemasonry has inculcated within us, may be able to show some of God's light for others to rise by.

*'Courage, brother! Do not stumble,
Though thy path is dark as night;
There's a star to guide the humble:
'Trust in God, and do the Right.'*

Norman Macleod

As Freemasons – and especially as Royal Arch Companions – we need not fear the dark. If we allow it to, our Order provides us with all the tools we need to walk this life without fear of any kind, confident that we are supported every step of the way. It's not that we never stumble: we do, and sometimes we fall. It's not that there isn't darkness in our lives: of course there is, and sometimes it feels as if it's more than we can bear. But if we remember to raise our eyes, that guiding star is always there for us, constant and unchanging, lighting our way and guiding our feet towards what we know, deep down, is truth and freedom and peace.

*'...yet from those flames
No light, but rather darkness visible
Serv'd only to discover sights of woe...'*

John Milton

As Freemasons, we have a hope that there exists a greater life beyond this one and that within our mortal frame there resides a spark of the Divine. At our exaltation into the Royal Arch, we descended into the darkness of the vault and found there the Great Light of God's word. Is it not possible, then, that this idea of 'darkness visible' is simply a reflection of the fact that the 'lesser lights' of the sun and moon are physical and temporary? Therefore, it follows that when taken with eternity in view, the light they shine is only physical and temporary and illumines only the outer form of things: the material world. On the other hand, the great, emblematical Light of the Volume of the Sacred Law illumines deeper, inner truths. In the East there is a tradition that suggests that this world is an illusion, but this does not mean that it is false, only that it is temporary and therefore unreal. What is real is eternal and it is this that is illuminated by the spiritual light of God's word.

‘Deep into that darkness peering, long I stood there wondering, fearing...’

Edgar Allan Poe

Doubt and questioning are part of what makes us human. To ask questions is, ultimately, what leads us to find answers. To put our philosophy and our beliefs to the test, constantly and rigorously, is important if we are to learn to trust their strength and usefulness. We often wonder what our next step in life will bring us to; we fear the unknown and waver on that cliff-top of uncertainty. This is natural and understandable, but if we do not take the next step – that leap of faith – we will not grow. The caterpillar that does not spin the dark cocoon around itself will never become a butterfly. The seed that does not crack and split will never be a tree. It is not in our nature to stand still and atrophy. We are living, growing creatures reaching up towards the emblematical light that is God. Pause if you must; recognise your doubt and fear, embrace them, own them. And then, if you want to be all that you could be, leap.

‘This is none other but the house of God, and this is the gate of Heaven.’

Genesis 28:16

In a Royal Arch Chapter as much as in a Freemason’s Lodge, the symbolism of the ladder that Jacob dreamed of is a key to our understanding of how we, as Masons, wish to live. Remember, the ladder rests on the truth of God’s word; its rungs represent all the moral virtues, but most especially Faith, Hope and Love or Charity, and the Mason who fully manifests these virtues in life is deemed to have achieved the summit of Freemasonry which is, ‘figuratively speaking, an ethereal mansion, not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.’

Just as Jacob awoke from his dream and realised that he had had a true vision, so must we remember the truth of our understanding that, even for us, the lessons of Jacob’s ladder offer us a vision of the house of God and a key to the gate of Heaven.

‘Fiat lux.’ (Let there be light.)

Genesis 1:3

The idea of light as a symbol of all that is good is one that can be found in every part of the globe. It is a concept that has been with us since the earliest periods of time, from the very dawn of human consciousness. It is something that is hard-wired into us on a primal level. For Freemasons, too, the symbolism of light is key. In our Lodges, heaven itself is represented by stars, God’s works by the sun and moon; we talk of great and lesser lights and, in the third degree, we welcome the return of the ‘bright morning star.’ In the Chapter we acknowledge the source of that light, both emblematical and physical, and begin to look beyond its physical manifestations and into the light of spirit that illumines our inner world. The catenarian arch, that symbol of strength and perfection, has inscribed on it the words, ‘Fiat lux’ and it is only by trusting that light that we are able to break into the darkness to find the wellspring of truth.

It is a real irony that the one thing that all Freemasons must agree on is also one of the things that we do not discuss at our meetings. We acknowledge the Supreme Being, we even offer up prayers and hymns, but the one thing we do not do is discuss the nature of our understanding of what God is. Freemasonry's great strength is its breadth, the fact that people from all religions and cultures are welcomed under its banner. For this to happen, though, we must be very careful to avoid anything that could cause division amongst us and one of those things could easily be disagreements about the nature of God. Therefore, Freemasonry leaves us the freedom to conceive of God according to our own nature, religion, culture or inclination, secure in the firm faith that God does exist and that, whatever we imagine that Divine nature to be, it is eternal and unchanging.

'Be strong and of good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the Lord thy God is with thee...'

Joshua 1:9

We do not come to Freemasonry to find faith. To enter Freemasonry we must already have faith and be willing to acknowledge openly our belief in a Supreme Being. Freemasonry may help to deepen our faith and to render it more secure although, strictly speaking, these things come more within the scope of our chosen religious paths. Freemasonry is more about the practical application of our faith, about how we use it to make the world a better place for ourselves, our connections and beyond. Being secure in this faith, and motivated by the highest of ideals, we are able to tread the paths of life with strength and courage, undismayed by setbacks and failures because, deep down, we know that God is with and within all of us.

'Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.'

Exodus 19:18/Matthew 19:18

Freemasonry encourages us to see all of humanity as one family under God. It shows us our interconnectedness, our inter-reliance, the bonds of love, care and respect that unite us. We cannot fail to notice the repeated references in our rituals to the fact that the 'rays of heaven' shine on all. Therefore, we must, of necessity, begin to develop the sense of humility that is a sign of our understanding that we are part of everything that is base about human nature as well as part of its highest aspirations. We cannot separate ourselves from any part of human life and when we see images of disease and war and hunger, we must know that it is ourselves and our family who fight and starve and die. Freemasons openly declare their connection to humanity and, therefore, they consciously take on a responsibility to help all those who suffer. Let us determine to do all we can to love our neighbours from every corner of the globe.

*'Sing unto God, sing praises to his name: extol him that rideth upon the heavens by his name JAH,
and rejoice before him.'*

Psalm 68:4

Ultimately, all the paths of this life lead us to one place, a place where every Freemason has – emblematically, at least – already been: the grave. Our time on Earth is so short, this life is so sweet for those of us lucky enough to have known love and to have had the time to appreciate the natural beauty that surrounds us. What else can we do but let our hearts sing the praises of our Creator? How else can we prevent them bursting with the joy that fills us when we contemplate all that makes us human?

For all its troubles and disappointments, all its suffering and injustices, this life still holds the possibility of happiness and peace. Sometimes we would do well to remember this and simply go out into the world to share our joy and our appreciation for what we have and what we know to be true.

Afterword:

If you have enjoyed this book, perhaps you would be good enough to review it in your favourite eBookstore.

You may also be interested in these titles by the same author:

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